

Florida Fishing Seasons Calendar

Month-by-Month Guide to South Florida Fishing

Miami, the Keys, and Beyond

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Introduction

South Florida does not have four traditional seasons. We have two: the dry season (November through April) and the wet season (May through October). But the fishing calendar follows a far more complex rhythm driven by water temperature, Gulf Stream position, bait migrations, spawning cycles, and the movement of pelagic species along the Atlantic coast.

Understanding what is biting and when is the difference between a banner day and an empty cooler. This calendar covers the major species targeted from Miami through the Florida Keys, with notes on FWC regulations, migration timing, and the environmental triggers that turn the bite on.

January

What is Biting

Sailfish: Peak season. The winter migration is in full swing with fish stacked along the reef edge from Haulover south to Fowey Rocks. Kite fishing and live-bait drifting in 100-180 feet are the primary techniques. Tournament season is heavy -- expect company on the water from Sailfish Marina north to Haulover.

Kingfish: Big smoker kings (30-60+ lbs) are thick along the reef edges. Slow-trolling live blue runners and goggle eyes on wire stinger rigs. Best bite is often early morning on the first and second reef.

Wahoo: The full moon bite in January can be spectacular. Troll high-speed lures and rigged ballyhoo along current edges in 200-600 feet. The wahoo bite often coincides with north current (unusual reversals that stack bait along temperature breaks).

Blackfin Tuna: Schooling in 200-400 feet along the Gulf Stream edge. Live pilchards, small feathers, and cedar plugs trolled at 6-8 knots. Excellent sashimi-grade fish.

Yellowtail Snapper: Feeding aggressively on the reef and patch reefs, especially in the Keys. Cool, clear water makes for excellent yellowtail fishing.

Grouper: CLOSED in Atlantic federal waters (January 1 through April 30). Focus on Gulf-side waters where regulations differ, or target catch-and-release.

Conditions

- Water temp: 72-76 degrees
- Gulf Stream: Close to shore, often within 1-2 miles
- Cold fronts every 5-10 days; best fishing 2-3 days after a front passes
- Predominant winds: NE to E, 10-20 knots between fronts

February

What is Biting

Sailfish: Still peak season. February often produces the highest numbers of the winter migration. The Quest for the Crest tournament series and other sailfish events run through February. Kite fishing remains the dominant technique.

Kingfish: Continuing strong. The largest kings of the season are often caught in February on the deeper reef edges (second and third reef) in 90-130 feet.

Cobia: Starting to show up along the reef edges, following spotted eagle rays. Sight-fishing for cobia from the tower or bow is productive. Live eels, live crabs, and large jigs are the go-to presentations.

Mutton Snapper: Pre-spawn feeding begins. Muttons start moving to staging areas on reef ledges in 60-100 feet. Not yet the full spawn frenzy, but catch rates improve over January.

Hogfish: Excellent hogfish fishing on the patch reefs in 15-40 feet throughout the Keys. Light knocker rigs with live shrimp.

Swordfish: Daytime deep-dropping is productive year-round, but the full moon periods in February can produce multiple hookups. Drop zones east of Miami in 1,200-1,800 feet.

Conditions

- Water temp: 71-75 degrees
- Cold fronts still regular but less intense than January
- Clearest water of the year -- visibility 60-100+ feet on the reef
- Best month for calm, cold-water fishing days

March

What is Biting

Sailfish (Late Season): The tail end of the sailfish migration. Numbers taper off through March but fish are still present into early April. The last tournament events of the season run in March.

Mahi-Mahi (Early Season): The first schools of mahi start pushing in from the south as water temperatures climb. Early-season mahi are often larger (bulls 30-50 lbs) because the schoolies have not arrived yet. Run offshore to current edges and weed lines in 200-600 feet.

Kingfish: Still strong through mid-March, tapering by month's end as water warms.

Tarpon (Keys): The first tarpon of the spring migration appear in the Keys by mid to late March. Fish stage in channels and basins, particularly around Islamorada and Marathon. Bridge fishing starts to produce.

Cobia: Peak month for cobia along the Miami reef line. Migrating fish follow rays and cruise the surface near channel markers and buoys. Sight-casting is the most exciting method.

Permit (Keys): Permit begin staging on wrecks and channel edges in preparation for spawning. Live crabs fished near structure.

Conditions

- Water temp: 74-78 degrees (warming trend)
- Gulf Stream begins to shift slightly offshore
- Transition month: last cold fronts mix with early warm-season patterns
- Wind: Variable, lighter days more frequent
- Lobster season closes March 31 in the Keys

April

What is Biting

Mahi-Mahi: The mahi season is building. Schools of schoolie-size fish (5-15 lbs) start mixing with larger fish. Weed lines, current edges, and floating debris are magnets. Trolling skirted ballyhoo and flounder lures covers water; when you find fish, stop and chunk.

Mutton Snapper (Pre-Spawn): Muttons are staging hard on reef ledges, feeding aggressively as they build up for the May full moon spawn. Target the GPS spots marked as mutton ledges in 50-90 feet with live pilchards on knocker rigs.

Tarpon (Keys): Numbers increasing weekly. Bridge fishing at Bahia Honda, Seven Mile, and Long Key produces good catches. Oceanside flats in Islamorada start holding rolling and laid-up fish.

Permit (Keys): Peak permit season beginning. Content Keys, Islamorada flats, and wrecks in 20-40 feet.

Bonito / False Albacore: Schooling along the reef edge and in the current. Not the best table fare but excellent sport and prime cut bait for other species.

Conditions

- Water temp: 76-80 degrees
- Afternoon thunderstorms begin developing (not yet daily)
- Wind: Predominantly SE, 8-15 knots
- Water clarity remains good
- Grouper season remains CLOSED in Atlantic federal waters through April 30

May

What is Biting

Mutton Snapper (Spawn): The May full moon mutton spawn is one of the most anticipated events on the South Florida fishing calendar. Mutton snapper concentrate on specific reef ledges in 40-90 feet and feed with reckless abandon during the full moon period. Live pilchards, cut ballyhoo, and threadfin herring on knocker rigs produce limits. The GPS spots in your package marked as mutton spawning ledges are exactly where you need to be.

Mahi-Mahi: Peak season arriving. Large schools offshore with a good mix of bulls and cows. The best numbers often come in late May when weed lines are fully established.

Tarpon (Keys): Peak migration. May and June are the prime months. Bahia Honda Bridge, Seven Mile Bridge, and the oceanside channels of Islamorada are loaded. Night bridge fishing with live mullet produces the largest fish.

Grouper Season Opens (May 1): Black grouper, red grouper, and gag grouper season opens in Atlantic federal waters. The wrecks and deep reef spots in your GPS package come alive. Live blue runners and large pinfish on heavy knocker rigs fished tight to structure.

Yellowtail Snapper: Good fishing continues though effort shifts to muttons and grouper during May.

Permit: Peak month. Flats fishing in the Keys is world-class. Marquesas trips produce trophy fish.

Conditions

- Water temp: 79-83 degrees
- Afternoon thunderstorms become more regular
- Calm mornings are the rule -- plan offshore runs for first light
- Gulf Stream pushes farther offshore, requiring longer runs for blue water

June

What is Biting

Mutton Snapper (Late Spawn): The June full moon continues the mutton spawn. Often slightly less intense than May but still excellent. Some of the largest muttons of the year are caught during the June moon.

Mahi-Mahi: Peak season continues. Hot offshore fishing for schools of dolphin on weed lines and current edges. June often produces the highest volume of mahi for the year.

Tarpon (Keys): Still peak season. The biggest tarpon (150-200 lbs) often move through in June.

Mangrove Snapper (Spawn): Mangrove snapper begin spawning on reefs, wrecks, and hard bottom in 60-120 feet. Night fishing on wrecks with live shrimp or pilchards produces big mangos (5-10+ lbs).

Grouper: Season is open and fishing is good. The initial pressure from opening day has subsided and fish are feeding more naturally.

Blackfin Tuna: Good numbers on the humps and reef edges, especially around new and full moons.

Swordfish: Nighttime swordfishing picks up in summer. Calm seas make the long runs to the drop zones more comfortable.

Conditions

- Water temp: 82-86 degrees
- Daily afternoon thunderstorms are the norm
- Fish early, be off the water by 1-2 PM
- Calm mornings with building seas through the day
- Lobster mini-season approaching (late July)

July

What is Biting

Mahi-Mahi (Late Season): Still good offshore but numbers begin to taper by late July. The fish that remain are often larger -- the schools have thinned out and the survivors have been eating well.

Mangrove Snapper: Peak spawning month. Reef and wreck fishing for spawning mangroves is some of the best fishing of the summer. Night trips are particularly productive.

Grouper: Good fishing continues through the summer. Early morning drops on deep wrecks before the current picks up.

Yellowfin Tuna (Humps): The Marathon Humps and 409 Hump produce yellowfin tuna in the 20-80 lb class. Jigging and chunking over the humps on calm days. This is a long run -- 25+ miles from shore -- so weather windows are critical.

Tarpon (Late Season): Tarpon numbers declining in the Keys but still fishable through mid-July, especially in the Lower Keys and Key West.

Lobster Mini-Season: The last consecutive Wednesday and Thursday of July. Two-day recreational season before the regular season opens August 6. Your GPS spots include productive lobster grounds -- use them responsibly and stay out of sanctuary zones.

Conditions

- Water temp: 84-88 degrees (peak)
- Hottest month -- hydration and sun protection are critical
- Storms can be severe; watch for waterspouts
- Light winds many mornings, building afternoon SE breeze
- Weed lines and debris can be pushed far offshore by summer currents

August

What is Biting

Snapper Month: August is dominated by snapper fishing. Mangrove snapper spawning continues, yellowtail are active, and muttons are caught incidentally on the reef. Multi-species snapper trips on the reef in 60-120 feet produce mixed bags.

Grouper: Consistent fishing through the summer. Black grouper on the deeper wrecks, reds on the shallower reef structure.

Lobster: Regular season opens August 6 (verify current date with FWC). Your GPS spots include reef and wreck structures that hold lobster.

Bonito and False Albacore: Thick along the reef edge, providing excellent sport and cut bait for reef fishing.

Sharks: Shark fishing is excellent in summer. Blacktip, spinner, bull, and hammerhead sharks feed on the reef and in the shallows. Live bonito chunks and large cut baits fished on the reef edge. Check FWC regulations -- some species are prohibited.

Conditions

- Water temp: 84-88 degrees
- Scattered afternoon storms continue
- Some years bring Saharan dust events that reduce visibility and slow reef fishing
- Sargassum weed mats can pile up along the coast

September

What is Biting

The Transition Month. September is when the fishing calendar begins to shift from summer to fall patterns. It is also the peak of hurricane season -- watch forecasts closely.

Snapper: Continues strong. Night yellowtail trips on the deeper reef are excellent.

Grouper: Still open and fishing well. September grouper on deep wrecks can be outstanding because fishing pressure is at its lowest.

Wahoo (Early): The first wahoo of the fall season start appearing along current edges in 200-400 feet. Not yet reliable, but worth running a wahoo lure in the spread.

Mahi (Scattered): Occasional schools still present but not consistent enough to target specifically.

Bonefish (Keys): Fall bonefishing picks up as tourist pressure drops. Lower Keys flats produce excellent sight-fishing.

Conditions

- Water temp: 83-86 degrees (beginning to cool late in the month)
- Peak hurricane season -- monitor weather closely
- Fewer boats on the water; some of the most peaceful fishing days of the year
- Afternoon storms less predictable than mid-summer

October

What is Biting

The Underrated Month. October is arguably the best-kept secret in South Florida fishing. The summer crowds are gone, the water is still warm, and fall migrations are beginning.

Kingfish (Early): The first kings of the fall migration push through in mid to late October. Scattered fish on the reef edge -- slow-trolling live bait along the second and third reef.

Sailfish (Early): The first sailfish of the winter migration appear in late October. Not yet reliable numbers, but kite fishermen start deploying and finding fish.

Wahoo: Fall wahoo season builds through October. Troll high-speed lures along current edges during the full and new moon periods.

Yellowtail Snapper: Excellent fishing as water temperatures drop into the high 70s and the water clears.

Hogfish: Beginning to return to shallower patch reefs as water cools.

Grouper: Still open and producing well. October is an excellent month for grouper on the deep wrecks and ledges.

Conditions

- Water temp: 79-83 degrees (cooling trend)
- First cold fronts of the season possible (weak, brief)
- Predominantly calm weather -- some of the best sea conditions of the year
- Minimal afternoon thunderstorm activity
- Falling tourist pressure = less boat traffic

November

What is Biting

The Switch. November is when South Florida fishing transitions into its peak winter mode. The pelagic migrations arrive and the reef fishing stays strong.

Sailfish: The migration is on. Numbers build through November with consistent catches by mid-month. Kite fishing season opens in earnest.

Kingfish: Fully arrived. Big kings on the reef edges from Haulover to Fowey Rocks. The annual kingfish tournaments begin.

Wahoo: Strong bite continues, especially on full and new moon phases. November wahoo fishing in the current can be world-class.

Cobia: Migrating fish appear along the reef, following rays and staging around channel markers and buoys.

Blackfin Tuna: Schools forming along the Gulf Stream edge. Excellent fishing on live pilchards and small feathers.

Yellowtail Snapper: Water clarity improves dramatically after the wet season ends. Yellowtail fishing on the patch reefs enters its best period.

Lobster: Regular season continues through March. Good lobstering on the reefs.

Conditions

- Water temp: 76-80 degrees
- Cold fronts begin with regularity (every 7-10 days)
- NE winds 10-20 knots between fronts
- Gulf Stream pushes closer to shore as fall progresses
- Clear, blue water moves inshore

December

What is Biting

Peak Season Begins. December marks the start of South Florida's busiest fishing period. Sailfish tournaments, holiday visitors, and perfect weather combine for incredible fishing.

Sailfish: Full migration underway. December through February is the heart of sailfish season. Tournament fleet is out in force. Kite fishing in 100-180 feet from Haulover to Government Cut.

Kingfish: Excellent. Live bait, slow-trolling, and drift fishing along the reef produce big fish.

Wahoo: December full moon wahoo fishing is legendary. Run to the current edges with high-speed lures at first light.

Swordfish: Strong daytime bite during full moon periods. The deep-drop fleet is active.

Yellowtail Snapper: Peak winter fishing. Keys patch reefs are loaded.

Hogfish: Active on patch reefs and scattered hard bottom. Prime time for hogfish in the Keys.

Grouper: Season runs through December 31 in Atlantic federal waters. Last chance before the January 1 closure -- make it count.

Conditions

- Water temp: 73-77 degrees
- Cold fronts regular, with excellent fishing windows between them
- Shortest days of the year -- maximize the morning bite
- Gulf Stream tight to shore -- blue water sometimes visible from the beach
- Holiday boat traffic increases, especially Christmas week through New Year's

FWC Regulation Highlights

IMPORTANT: Regulations change. The information below is a general reference only. Always verify current rules at MyFWC.com or on the Fish Rules app before fishing.

Key Season Closures (Atlantic Federal Waters -- South Florida)

| Species | Open Season | Notes | |-----|-----|-----| | Black Grouper | May 1 - Dec 31 | Closed Jan 1 - Apr 30 | | Red Grouper | May 1 - Dec 31 | Closed Jan 1 - Apr 30 | | Gag Grouper | May 1 - Dec 31 | Closed Jan 1 - Apr 30 | | Mutton Snapper | Year-round | Special spawning season rules May-June in some zones | | Yellowtail Snapper | Year-round | Bag limit 10/person/day (verify current) | | Hogfish | May 1 - Oct 31 (Keys/SE FL) | Season varies by region | | Greater Amberjack | Check current FWC | Frequent closures and amendments | | King Mackerel | Year-round | Bag limit 2/person/day | | Cobia | Year-round (state waters) | 1/person/day, 33-inch minimum fork length | | Spiny Lobster | Aug 6 - Mar 31 (regular); mini-season in July | Bag limits and trap rules apply |

General Rules

- Reef fish (grouper, snapper) require descending devices or venting tools when fishing in deep water to release fish safely.
- All billfish (sailfish, marlin, spearfish) are catch-and-release only in Florida state waters.
- Federal HMS (Highly Migratory Species) permit required for billfish, swordfish, and tunas in federal waters.
- Nassau grouper and goliath grouper are completely prohibited from harvest.

- Bag limits are per person, per day, and cannot be accumulated across trips.
- Size limits are measured in total length or fork length depending on the species -- know which measurement applies.

Understanding the Environmental Triggers

Water Temperature

The single most important factor in South Florida fishing. Almost every species pattern described in this calendar is driven by water temperature:

- **Below 70 degrees:** Cold stunts. Snook and tarpon become lethargic. Rare in South Florida but happens during severe January cold fronts. Reef fish slow down.
- **70-75 degrees:** Peak winter fishing. Sailfish, kingfish, wahoo, and cobia are most active. Reef fish feed well.
- **75-80 degrees:** Transition temps. Mahi arrive, tarpon migration begins, mutton spawn triggers.
- **80-85 degrees:** Summer mode. Snapper spawning, grouper active but deeper. Pelagics offshore on current edges.
- **Above 85 degrees:** Peak summer. Some reef species become less active during midday. Fish early and deep.

Gulf Stream Position

The Gulf Stream's inner edge acts as a highway for migratory species. When the Stream pushes close to shore (winter), sailfish, kingfish, wahoo, and tuna are accessible with short runs. When it pushes offshore (summer), you burn more fuel to reach the blue water.

Monitor the Stream position using SST (sea surface temperature) satellite imagery before every offshore trip. Services like Hilton's Realtime Navigator, ROFFS, and FishWeather provide current data.

Moon Phase

Affects tides, bait movement, and feeding intensity:

- **Full Moon:** Strongest tides, mutton snapper spawn trigger, excellent night fishing
- **New Moon:** Darkest nights, concentrated feeding at dawn/dusk, good offshore fishing
- **Quarter Moons:** Moderate conditions, consistent fishing

Bait Presence

Follow the bait and you find the fish. If you cannot locate bait (pilchards, ballyhoo, threadfin) in their normal spots, the fishing will be slow regardless of what the calendar says. Conversely, if bait is stacked thick on the reef or flats, predators will be nearby.

Final Notes

This calendar is a framework, not a guarantee. Fish do not read calendars, and South Florida weather can override any seasonal pattern. A January warm spell can shut down the sailfish bite. A cool summer front can trigger unexpected kingfish action. The best anglers use the calendar as a starting point and adjust based on

real-time conditions -- water temperature, current, bait presence, and what the fish are actually doing today.

Your GPS spots combined with this seasonal knowledge put you ahead of 90% of anglers on the water. But the last 10% comes from time on the water, paying attention to the details, and building your own understanding of how these fisheries work.

Fish smart, fish legal, and respect the resource.

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DISCLAIMER: Fishing seasons, bag limits, and regulations change frequently. This calendar is a general reference and does not constitute legal advice. Always verify current FWC regulations at MyFWC.com before fishing. GPS coordinates and fishing recommendations are provided as-is without warranty.